

HiddenStay

*A Fair-Commission Accommodation Marketplace
with Integrated AI Trip Planner for Independent Hotels in Southeast Asia*

Course: BU3102 / CP3102 — Business and Information Technology Capstone

Group: 63 I

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Glossary of Terms

All industry terms used in this proposal are defined below. No jargon is used without explanation.

Term	Definition
OTA (Online Travel Agency)	A website or app that lists hotels and takes bookings on behalf of properties (e.g. Booking.com, Expedia). The OTA charges the hotel a commission on each booking.
Commission	The percentage of a booking payment kept by the platform. If a guest pays SGD 100 and commission is 20%, the platform keeps SGD 20 and the hotel receives SGD 80.
Independent hotel	A property that is not part of a large international chain (e.g. a family-run guesthouse, boutique inn, or eco-lodge). These hotels usually cannot negotiate lower OTA fees.
EBITDA per available room	A profit measure used in the hotel industry: earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortisation, divided by the number of rooms available. It shows how much profit a hotel makes per room, before financing costs. Lower EBITDA means the hotel earns less from each room.
MVP (Minimum Viable Product)	The smallest working version of the product needed to test the idea and meet capstone requirements.
UAT (User Acceptance Testing)	Structured testing with real users (e.g. pilot hotel partners) to confirm features work as expected.
Capstone scope	Features we must deliver in the 10-week graded project.
Post-capstone vision	Business goals after graduation — not part of the graded MVP.

Executive Summary

HiddenStay is a capstone web platform that connects travellers with independent hotels, homestays, and eco-lodges across Southeast Asia while charging a **5% commission** — far below the 15–30% fees charged by major Online Travel Agencies (OTAs). The project addresses two linked market failures: independent hotels lose margin to high distribution costs, and travellers lack a single tool that combines fair-priced booking with AI-assisted, map-ready trip planning.

Our five-member interdisciplinary team (Project Management, Development, UI/UX, Business Analysis, and Marketing) will deliver a functional MVP within **10 weeks**. Capstone deliverables include a secure booking website with role-based portals (traveller, host, admin), Stripe sandbox payments with engine-enforced 5% commission, a host dashboard, five verified pilot listings, and an AI Trip Planner that outputs structured itineraries with Google Places coordinates.

The AI planner is not scope creep — it creates a demand channel for the same inventory the marketplace lists. Travellers who plan a trip in HiddenStay are shown bookable local properties along their route, reducing discovery friction for small hotels without OTA advertising spend.

Success will be measured against SMART objectives: $\geq 90\%$ UAT pass rate on core journeys, 5.00% commission on all test bookings, five live pilot listings, and $\geq 80\%$ of AI-generated stops with valid map coordinates. Post-capstone, the team envisions scaling to 50+ hotel partners and 500+ monthly bookings, but these commercial targets are explicitly outside the graded scope.

This proposal outlines the problem context, project organisation, scope partition, unified team code of conduct, day-level project schedule, risk register with named owners, stakeholder analysis, and academic references supporting our market rationale.

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Problem Statement

2.1 Context

Small and independent hotels in Southeast Asia depend on **Online Travel Agencies (OTAs)** — booking websites such as Booking.com and Expedia — to reach international travellers. OTAs provide visibility and bookings, but charge **commission fees of roughly 15% to 30%** on each reservation.

2.2 Literature Review — Host (Supply-Side) Problem

Research on hotel distribution channels shows a **contradiction** for independent properties:

- OTAs **increase room sales** by connecting hotels to a large online audience (Juniarta et al., 2026; Hospitalitynet.org, 2024).
- At the same time, OTA dependence **reduces profit margins**, because commission fees consume a large share of revenue — especially for **budget and independent hotels** that cannot negotiate chain rates (Juniarta et al., 2026).
- In Southeast Asia, independent hotels route a **much higher share of online bookings through OTAs** than chain hotels do, which increases their exposure to these fees (Hospitalitynet.org, 2024).
- Industry reports note **recent commission increases** targeting independent properties on major OTAs (Hospitality Technology, 2024; PhocusWire, 2024).

Summary: OTAs help hotels get guests, but the **cost of distribution is disproportionately high** for small independent operators. A survey cited by Juniarta et al. (2026) found that **most hotel managers consider OTA fees too high**.

For the literature review, we cite the direction and magnitude of findings in plain language. Statistical details (regression coefficients) belong in the original paper, not in this proposal.

2.3 Industry Problem — Traveller (Demand-Side)

Travellers who want **local, boutique, or eco-friendly stays** face a separate problem: **trip planning is fragmented**. A typical journey involves:

1. Inspiration (social media, blogs)
2. Route planning (maps, spreadsheets)
3. Activity research (review sites)
4. Accommodation booking (OTA apps)
5. On-trip navigation (another map app)

Switching between **five or more tools** increases planning time and cognitive load. Generic AI chatbots can suggest activities, but often output **text-only lists** without map coordinates, opening hours, or links to **bookable nearby independent hotels**.

2.4 Problem Statement

Independent hotels in Southeast Asia pay high OTA commissions that erode profit, while travellers lack a single platform that combines fair-priced booking of small properties with AI-assisted, map-ready trip planning. HiddenStay addresses both gaps: a **5% commission**

marketplace built for independent hotels, integrated with an **AI trip planner** that produces day-by-day itineraries with real map locations and bookable stays.

Hidden Content: Proposal

Why the AI Trip Planner Matters

Commission savings alone do not create traveller demand. HiddenStay's **AI trip planner** is motivated by three concrete user problems:

3.1 Problem: Planning Friction

Without integrated planner	With HiddenStay planner
User copies suggestions from ChatGPT into Google Maps manually	AI outputs stops with Google Places IDs and coordinates
Hotel booked separately from daily activities	Itinerary and booking live in one app
No link between "things to do" and "where to stay"	Planner surfaces HiddenStay listings near each stop

User story: A traveller planning 5 days in Chiang Mai currently spends hours cross-referencing blogs, maps, and Booking.com. HiddenStay reduces this to one flow: describe the trip → receive a **map-ready itinerary** → book an independent stay near the route.

3.2 Problem: Generic AI Travel Advice

Most AI tools recommend famous landmarks already crowded with tour groups. HiddenStay's planner is designed to support **discovery of independent stays and hidden gems**, aligned with the platform's positioning — not chain hotels at the top of OTA search results.

3.3 Problem: Conversion Gap for Small Hotels

Independent hotels struggle with **discovery**, not just fees. The planner creates a **demand channel**: travellers who plan a trip in HiddenStay are shown bookable local properties along their route, increasing visibility without OTA advertising spend.

3.4 Measurable Capstone Goal (Links to Objective 5)

Goal	How we measure
Map-ready AI stops	≥80% of planner stops have valid Google Places coordinates (validation script on 30 sample itineraries)

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***Why this is not "scope creep":** The planner is not a separate product — it drives **search** → **book** conversion for the same inventory the marketplace lists.*

Why It Is Practical and Necessary

Practical viability: The capstone MVP employs Next.js 15, Express, Prisma, PostgreSQL (Supabase), Stripe sandbox, Google Maps/Places, and multi-provider LLM endpoints — all demonstrable within 10 weeks by a five-member team executing parallel workstreams.

Economic necessity: With a 5% fee, a SGD 100/night booking gives the hotel SGD 95. With a typical 20–30% OTA fee, the hotel only keeps SGD 70–80. For hotels with tight margins, this difference really matters.

Commission Comparison — SGD 100 Booking Scenarios

Platform / Fee Rate	Commission (SGD)	Hotel Receives (SGD)	Hotel Keeps
HiddenStay (5%)	5.00	95.00	95%
Typical OTA (20%)	20.00	80.00	80%
Typical OTA (25%)	25.00	75.00	75%
Typical OTA (30%)	30.00	70.00	70%

Travel in Southeast Asia has recovered well after COVID. More travellers want local and boutique stays, but small hotels are still hard to find without using expensive OTAs. HiddenStay gives them a cheaper way to get online bookings.

SMART Objectives (Capstone MVP — Weeks 1–10)

Our goals follow SMART criteria (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound).

#	Objective	Success Indicator / KPI	Measurement Method
1	Build a functional web OTA enabling independent hotel listing, search, and booking within the 10-week capstone.	Functional staging platform with core booking flow operational end-to-end.	UAT completion with ≥90% task-completion rate across defined user journeys.
2	Implement a 5% base commission model in the booking payment engine (sandbox).	Commission field persisted at 5.00% on all test bookings.	SQL audit of booking transaction logs; unit test assertions on fee computation.
3	Empower hotel partners with a self-service dashboard (calendar, bookings, pricing, basic analytics).	≥4 core dashboard features functional; ≥80% of pilot partners rate usefulness ≥4/5.	Feature checklist; post-onboarding partner survey (Likert scale).
4	Onboard 5 verified pilot hotel listings for capstone system stability testing.	5 live listings with photos, room types, pricing, and availability.	Database property count at Week 10; manual listing quality review.
5	Deliver an AI Trip Planner generating multi-day, geocoded, map-ready itineraries.	≥80% of AI-generated stops contain valid Google Places coordinates.	Automated coordinate validation script against 30 sample itineraries; QA report.

A. Project Organisation

HiddenStay is built by a 5-person student team with both business and IT skills. The table below shows each member's role and why they were chosen for that role.

No.	Member Name	Role	Key Responsibilities	Skills / Role Justification
1	Zaw Latt Naung	Project Manager	Sprint planning, risk monitoring, stakeholder communication, final documentation and submission	Project management and Agile coursework; organised past team projects and meeting coordination.
2	Oakkar Phyo	Lead Developer	Express/Prisma API, JWT auth, Stripe integration, AI engine, Google Places enrichment, deployment	Software engineering and full-stack web development modules; built production-grade APIs before.
3	Eka Dian Tara Tiu	UI/UX Designer	Wireframes, high-fidelity screens, design system, UAT facilitation, accessibility review	HCI and UI/UX coursework; experience with Figma, user testing, and responsive design.
4	Chenyang Gu	Business Analyst	Requirements document, user stories, commission modelling, literature review, UAT coordination	Business analysis and economics modules; comfortable with market research and financial modelling.
5	Yihua Deng	Marketing & Partnerships Lead	Pilot hotel outreach, partner onboarding, promotional materials, go-to-market strategy	Digital marketing coursework; experience with outreach, presentations, and partnership development.

Project Strategy

HiddenStay is a booking platform focused on Southeast Asia and built for small independent hotels. Users can search, list, book, and pay through a responsive web application, plus use an AI trip planner in the same system. The project follows an **Agile weekly sprint** model with parallel workstreams: business analysis and design run ahead of development in Weeks 1–6, while backend, frontend, and AI modules converge in Weeks 7–10.

Supply-before-demand strategy: We recruit pilot hotel partners first (via team contacts and free onboarding) to ensure bookable inventory exists before traveller-facing features go live. The Marketing & Partnerships Lead owns partner acquisition; the Business Analyst validates listing quality.

Technology strategy: Next.js 15 (frontend), Express + Prisma (backend), PostgreSQL on Supabase (database), Stripe sandbox (payments), Google Maps/Places (maps), and a multi-provider LLM fallback chain (Groq → Gemini → OpenAI) for AI resilience. GitHub Classroom hosts the codebase with feature-branch workflow and pull request reviews.

Parallel sprint design (Weeks 7–9): Backend finalises booking and dashboard APIs while the Lead Developer implements AI itinerary generation; the UI/UX Designer and Developer integrate both into the planner UI simultaneously.

B. Project Scope

B.1 Proposed Solution

HiddenStay tries to solve both supply-side and demand-side problems with one platform: a lower-commission booking site (5% base fee) and an AI trip planner that creates map-ready itineraries with real place data. The platform serves three user roles: **Travellers** (search, book, plan trips), **Hotel Owners** (list properties, manage bookings), and **Administrators** (verify listings, monitor platform health).

B.2 Issues to Be Addressed

Issue	How HiddenStay Addresses It
High OTA fees	HiddenStay charges 5% instead of 15–30%, so hotels keep more money.
No fair booking option for small hotels	HiddenStay is built for independent SEA hotels, not big chains.
Weak hotel tools	Hotel dashboard helps partners manage bookings, calendar, and pricing.
Hard to discover small hotels	Search, filters, and AI planner surface independent hotels near trip stops.
Trip planning is scattered	AI planner builds day-by-day plans in the same app used for booking.
Generic AI travel suggestions	Google Places adds real venue names and map coordinates.

OTA Feature Comparison

Feature	Booking.com	Expedia	HiddenStay
Commission (independent hotels)	15–30%	15–30%	5% base (capstone MVP)
Independent hotel focus	Partial	Partial	Yes — core target segment
Integrated AI trip planner	No	Limited	Yes — structured JSON + Places
Map-ready geocoded itineraries	No	No	Yes — Google Maps integration

B.3 Capstone MVP Deliverables (10 Weeks)

We split the project into two parts: (1) **Capstone MVP** — what we must finish in 10 weeks, and (2) **Future Business Vision** — what the business could become after graduation.

These are the features we plan to build and demo during the 10-week capstone:

- User login/sign-up for travellers and hotel partners (JWT auth)
- Hotel partners can add listings with photos, rooms, prices, and availability
- Search hotels by destination, dates, price, and property type
- Book rooms and pay with Stripe sandbox (test mode only, no real money)
- Hotel dashboard for bookings, calendar, and basic stats
- AI trip planner using Groq/Gemini/OpenAI + Google Places + map view
- Traveller dashboard for saved trips, bookings, and AI chat

- Guest reviews after stays
- Admin listing approval workflow (PENDING → APPROVED)
- Deploy to a live staging URL (Vercel + Supabase)

Technical approach (AI module): We use structured JSON prompts, Google Places for real coordinates, and backup AI providers (Groq, Gemini, OpenAI) so the demo still works if one API fails.

AI module priority and contingency: (1) structured JSON itinerary generation and Google Places geocoding, (2) map visualisation with route rendering, (3) conversational AI chat refinement. If API integration risks arise during Weeks 7–9, the MVP will prioritise itinerary generation and map visualisation; advanced AI chat refinement may be deferred without blocking capstone submission.

B.3 Capstone MVP — Out of Scope

We will **NOT** build these in the capstone (to avoid scope creep):

- Real payment processing (we only use Stripe test mode)
- Multiple languages
- Publishing native iOS/Android apps
- Expansion to all SEA countries (capstone focuses on SG/MY testing)
- Advanced dynamic pricing engine
- Live production launch with real customer payments

B.4 Future Business Vision (Post-Capstone)

These are post-capstone business goals only (not graded in the 10-week MVP):

- 50+ hotel partners in Singapore and Malaysia by Month 9
- 200+ hotel partners and 500+ bookings/month by Month 12
- 500+ hotels across 6 SEA countries by Month 24
- Higher 10–15% promotional listing tiers with advertising features
- Release iOS and Android native mobile apps
- Break-even within 24 months (commission revenue $\geq$ operating costs)
- Investor pitch and funding preparation

B.5 Expected Project Outcomes

If the project goes well, these are the results we expect, split by capstone vs post-capstone:

Outcome	Target	Phase / Timeline
Staging site live	Core MVP features work on a public test URL	Capstone — Week 10
Pilot hotel listings	5 test hotels with photos, prices, availability	Capstone — Week 10
Booking flow works	$\geq 90\%$ of UAT test bookings complete without error	Capstone — Week 10
AI map accuracy	$\geq 80\%$ of AI stops have valid Google Places data	Capstone — Week 10
More hotel partners	50 partners in Singapore and Malaysia	After capstone — Month 9
Monthly bookings	500+ bookings/month	After capstone — Month 12
Large partner base	500+ hotels across 6 SEA countries	After capstone — Month 24
Break-even	Revenue covers operating costs	After capstone — Month 24

C. Project Management Plan

C.1 Team Code of Conduct, Decision-Making, Workflow & Integrity

All team members agree to the following **single code of conduct** for the HiddenStay capstone project.

A. Professional Behaviour

1. **Respect** — Treat every member fairly; criticise work, not people.
2. **Honesty** — Report progress, blockers, and risks early in weekly meetings; do not hide delays.
3. **Ownership** — Complete assigned tasks by agreed deadlines; flag conflicts before the deadline.
4. **Attendance** — Attend scheduled meetings; notify the group at least 24 hours in advance if absent.
5. **Quality** — Do not submit work that fails the sprint checklist; peer-review before merge.

B. Decision-Making

Decision Type	Process
Task-level (within one role)	Owner decides; informs team in weekly sync
Shared (design, priorities)	Discuss in weekly meeting; simple majority vote
Major (scope change, deadline slip)	All 5 members must agree; record in meeting minutes
Deadlock	Project Manager makes final call and logs rationale

C. Workflow & Files

- **Code:** GitHub Classroom repo, feature branches, pull request review before merge
- **Tasks:** Trello/Jira updated weekly by task owner
- **Documents:** Google Drive/OneDrive with versioned filenames
- **Communication:** Team chat for daily updates; meeting minutes for decisions

D. Conflict Resolution

1. Discuss directly within **48 hours**
2. Escalate to weekly team meeting
3. Project Manager decides if unresolved
4. Record outcome in project log

E. Integrity & Compliance

- Original work only; cite all sources — **no plagiarism**
- Do not promise hotel partners features not in the current build
- Follow **PDPA** when handling user or partner personal data
- Use Stripe **sandbox only** during capstone — no live payments without approval

C.2 Roles & Responsibilities

Full role details are in Section A. Each person has clear tasks so work does not overlap. The Project Manager keeps the schedule and communication on track. Weeks 7–8 are heavy for AI work, so we split

tasks: Lead Developer builds the AI engine and Google Places integration, while BA and PM work on prompts, JSON format, and itinerary UI pages.

C.7 Project Action Plan — Week Summary

Week	Phase	Key Deliverables	Owner(s)	Milestone
W1	Initiation	Team charter, literature review, role confirmation	PM + BA	Kick-off
W2	Analysis	Commission model, project kick-off milestone	BA + All	Analysis complete
W3	Requirements	Functional requirements, user stories begin	BA	Requirements draft
W4	Design	Wireframes, architecture diagram, requirements sign-off	Designer + Dev + BA	Design sign-off
W5–W6	UI Design	UI kit, high-fidelity screens (traveller + host), design approval	Designer	Design approval
W7–W8	Development Sprint 1	DB schema, auth API, property/search APIs, AI engine start	Dev + BA + PM	Sprint 1 demo
W9	Development Sprint 2	Booking + Stripe, host dashboard, reviews, AI/map integration	Dev + Designer	Sprint 2 + AI demo
W10	Closure	HiddenStay Project Proposal Integration testing, UAT, bug fixes, staging deploy, documentation	All	Capstone submission

C.8 Day-Level Gantt Chart

Capstone duration: 10 weeks · **Assumption:** Week 1 = Mon–Fri (5 working days each). **Legend:** W# D# = Week number, Day number (Mon=1 ... Fri=5).

ID	Task	Start	End	Days	Owner	Depends on
1.1	Team charter & role confirmation	W1 D1	W1 D2	2	PM	—
1.2	Literature review (OTA fees, SEA market)	W1 D2	W1 D5	4	BA	1.1
1.3	Commission comparison model	W2 D1	W2 D3	3	BA	1.2
1.4	Project kick-off milestone	W2 D5	W2 D5	1	All	1.3
2.1	Functional requirements document	W3 D1	W3 D3	3	BA	1.4
2.2	User stories (traveller, host, admin)	W3 D3	W3 D5	3	BA + Designer	2.1
2.3	System architecture diagram	W3 D4	W4 D2	4	Dev	2.1
2.4	Wireframes — search, listing, book	W4 D1	W4 D5	5	Designer	2.2
2.5	Requirements sign-off	W4 D5	W4 D5	1	All	2.4
3.1	UI kit & branding	W5 D1	W5 D3	3	Designer	2.5
3.2	High-fidelity screens — traveller flows	W5 D3	W6 D2	4	Designer	3.1
3.3	High-fidelity screens — host dashboard	W5 D5	W6 D3	3	Designer	3.1
3.4	Design approval	W6 D5	W6 D5	1	All	3.2, 3.3
4.1	DB schema + Prisma setup	W7 D1	W7 D2	2	Dev	3.4
4.2	Auth API (JWT)	W7 D2	W7 D4	3	Dev	4.1
4.3	Property listing API	W7 D4	W8 D2	4	Dev	4.2
4.4	Search API	W8 D2	W8 D4	3	Dev	4.3
4.5	Sprint 1 demo	W8 D5	W8 D5	1	Dev	4.4
5.1	Booking API + Stripe sandbox	W9 D1	W9 D3	3	Dev	4.5
5.2	Host dashboard (bookings, calendar)	W9 D2	W9 D4	3	Dev	5.1
5.3	Reviews module	W9 D4	W9 D5	2	Dev	5.1
5.4	Sprint 2 demo	W9 D5	W9 D5	1	Dev	5.3

ID	Task	Start	End	Days	Owner	Depends on
6.1	AI engine + API integration	W7 D3	W8 D3	6	Dev	4.2
6.2	Google Places enrichment	W8 D1	W8 D4	4	Dev	6.1
6.3	Prompt design + JSON schema	W7 D1	W8 D2	6	BA + PM	2.5
6.4	Itinerary UI pages	W8 D3	W9 D2	5	Designer + Dev	6.2, 6.3
6.5	Map view integration	W9 D1	W9 D4	4	Dev	6.4
6.6	AI module demo	W9 D5	W9 D5	1	All	6.5
7.1	Integration testing	W9 D3	W10 D2	4	All	5.4, 6.6
7.2	UAT with pilot hotels	W10 D1	W10 D3	3	BA + PM	7.1
7.3	Bug fix buffer	W10 D2	W10 D4	3	Dev	7.2
8.1	Staging deployment	W10 D3	W10 D4	2	Dev	7.3
8.2	Final documentation	W10 D4	W10 D5	2	All	8.1
8.3	Capstone submission	W10 D5	W10 D5	1	PM	8.2

C.9 Risk Register

This table lists main project risks, how likely they are, and how we plan to handle them. Every risk has a named owner responsible for weekly monitoring.

#	Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation	Risk Owner	Residual
R1	Low pilot hotel adoption	Medium	High	Free onboarding; team personal contacts for first 5 listings	Yihua Deng (Marketing)	Low–Med
R2	Lead Developer overload W7–8	High	High	Split AI track: Dev = APIs; BA/PM = prompts/UI	Zaw Latt Naung (PM) monitors load	Low
R3	Schedule overrun	Medium	Medium	Weekly sprint review; cut non-core features first	Zaw Latt Naung (PM)	Low
R4	Stripe integration delay	Medium	Medium	Start sandbox W7 D1; manual test booking fallback	Oakkar Phyoe (Dev)	Low
R5	AI API limits / downtime	Medium	Medium	Groq → Gemini → OpenAI fallback; cache itineraries	Oakkar Phyoe (Dev)	Low
R6	Data / security breach	Low	Very High	HTTPS, hashed passwords, PDPA soft-delete	Oakkar Phyoe (Dev)	Low
R7	Team member unavailable	Low	High	Docs in GitHub/Drive; cross-training on key modules	Zaw Latt Naung (PM)	Medium
R8	AI planner map accuracy below 80%	Medium	Medium	Validation script; manual Places lookup fallback	Chenyang Gu (BA)	Low
R9	UAT failure (<90% pass)	Medium	High	Test checklist from W9; buffer days W10 D2–D4	Eka Dian Tara Tiu (UX)	Low
R10	Scope creep (post-MVP features)	Medium	Medium	Written capstone scope; PM rejects out-of-scope tasks	Zaw Latt Naung (PM)	Low

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Risk owner duty: Monitor assigned risk weekly, report status in team meeting, trigger mitigation if likelihood or impact increases.

D. Stakeholder Analysis

Stakeholder	Interest	Influence	Capstone MVP Expectations
Travellers	High	Medium	Affordable stays + map-ready itineraries; web UX, search/book, AI with Places coords.
Independent Hotel Owners	High	Medium	Lower commission, visibility; 5% fee, self-service dashboard, pilot notifications.
Project Team & Academic Assessors	High	High	On-time MVP, competence demo; clear ownership, staging deploy, SMART evidence.
API & Payment Providers (Google, Stripe, LLM)	Medium	Low	Reliable sandbox integrations; quota/rate limits managed via fallback and caching.

References

These references support our problem statement and market background:

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— End of Proposal —